[Beloved did you forget . . .]
Beloved did you forget how you slept between my breasts
& why have you sold me forever into chains

Didn't I chase after you once in an untamed land
Mountains & sand, Dead Sea & Sinai my witnesses

You had my love & I was your desire, so how
Can you share out my riches without me?

Pushed into Seir, forced toward Kedar,
Turned in the furnace of Greece, abused in the bond of Iran

Who besides you could set me free
Who but me, so caged by hope?

Lend me your strength,
I will give you my tenderness

[Oh homeland don't you wonder]

Oh homeland don't you wonder on your captives,
who call to you, the ones left of your pastures

From seaward to sunrise, tree-line to barrens,
calling from far or close by from all sides

Call of a captive of desire, who sheds tears like dew
on Hermon's peaks, & longs to let them fall on your mountains

When I wail out your torment I'm a hound, & when I dream
your homecoming has come, I'm strung with your songs

My heart beats to Beth-El & louder at P'niel
& Makhanayim & every point your pure ones touched

Where the holy nearness filled your winds, your maker
opened your windows to the windows of skies

& only God's glow for your light, no
sun moon or stars to illuminate you

I would let my last breath spill out right where
the divine spirit overflowed your chosen ones

You're the royal home & the holy seat & how
have servants sat down on your heroes' thrones?

If only I could wander in the places
God was shown to your envoys & seers

& who will make me wings & I will range
with my heart in pieces between your ragged peaks

I would fall to my face on your ground & thrill
to your stones & feel your sweet dust with my fingers

& then standing on my ancestors' gravestones,
I'd be stunned in Hevron how your finest are buried there

I would cross your forests & terraces & pause
in awe at the Gilead ridgeline where Moses was buried

His & Aaron's burial mountains, those two huge
lights shining on you, showing you the way

Living breath — the air of your soil, & myrrh fragrance
the grains your earth, & honey-flow for your rivers

It would soothe my mind to go shoeless, naked
in the waste & ruins that were your shrines

Where your ark was hidden away, where cherubim
stayed in your innermost chambers

I'd shear off my hair grown in devotion, curse the years
in unclean lands that fouled your most devoted

How fine can the food on my plate taste when I see
your young lions dragged along by dogs?

Or how will daylight sweeten my eyes, while
I watch crows carry away their kill of your eagles

Slow now, cup of suffering, ease up, my belly
& soul are swollen with your bitterness

When I remember Jerusalem straying, I drink,
& her fallen sister Samaria, & I drain it

Zion loveliest crown, how you weave love & grace
as of old & your friends' souls woven through you

Those who smile if you're at peace & ache
at your desolation & weep for your shattered pieces

From a captive's pit yearning for you, each
in his place bowing toward the arches of your gates

Your numberless herds driven out & scattered
from mountain to hilltop but your fence-lines not forgotten

Who cling to your fringes & fight to climb
& grasp onto your date palms' canopies

Could Babylon & Egypt ever match you, their hollow
prayers compare to the gemstones you told truths with?

Who will compare to your nobles & holy men,
your chanters in the temple, singers in the choir?

False-god kingdoms will fall & be gone — your force
is forever, through the generations your jewels

God sought you for a home, & joy to a human who
has chosen, draws closer, to dwell in your courtyards

Joy to one who awaited, arrives, lays eyes
on your light dawning & your sunrises burst upon him

To see your chosen thriving, to thrill in your joy
as you come back to your long-ago bloom

[West, this is your wind, wings]

West, this is your wind, wings perfumed with balm & apple
You come from the trader's warehouses, not the storehouses of wind
You lift the swallow's wing calling me to freedom like the fragrance of just-picked aloes
How we all long for you, by whom we ride a few boards over the sea
Please don't ease off your touch on the ship when day catches up or settles down
Level the depths, spread the sea open, don't stop until you reach the holy mountains
Rebuff the easterly that thrashes up the seas until the waves seethe like a pot boiling over
But what can the wind do, bound in God's hand, now restrained, now he sends it?
My only wish: in the hand of the One on high who raises high mountains & makes the win

[In distances a dove]

In distances a dove strayed into a forest
lost, not knowing how to recover

Hovering, wings swinging spun
wheeling circles around her beloved

Counting down the millennia to redemption
but her figuring leaves her dumbfounded

Having suffered for her lover long years
of wandering, soul exposed to the grave

Saying I will no more remember his name
but it lights in her heart like flame:

Why would you be her enemy, her beak
parted for your salving spring rain

She believes to her depths, turning from despair
whether she's raised up or suffers by him

Let our God come, no longer silent
fire rising on all sides of him

[Gently, with your soft waist]

Gently, with your soft waist but heart hard, gently with me, I surrender.

Straying only with my eyes, my heart pure but my eyes drunk on you.

Let those eyes gather roses & lilies where they grow together

in your cheeks, from which I rake fire to fight fire & if I'm thirsty find water there.

I would sip the red lips glowing like coals, & my moth tongs. My life

suspends between those crimson lines but with sundown my death comes. Then

I find only nights with no end where once was no midnight for days, time

was in my hands like clay & constellations spun like the potter's wheel.

[Cry out, forest, for a cedar]

Cry out, forest, for a cedar, for one
who waited for daylight, but night fell.

No, I didn't know the Seven Sisters
could die with him, & the morning star.

[Lately with winter rains]

Lately with winter rains the land has nursed on a cloud like a baby
or like a bride shut in by the cold longing for days of love,
hours of touching, until spring comes to ease her aching heart.
Dressed in flowerbeds of gold & brocade the way a girl thrills
at her clothes as she changes & shares them with everyone.
Day by day the hues go amber to ruby to pearl,
turning pale or green & then reddening as if kissing.
So beautiful I wonder if they're stars stolen from heaven.
At dawn we come where the trees lean with wine & our hearts flaring,
wine snow-cool to the fingers that lights fire inside us
rising from its jug like a sun to flow into our fine glasses.
As we stroll under the garden's shade it laughs at a rain shower weeping,
smiles when a cloud cries shaking off droplets like a burst necklace,
savoring the swallow-call like liquor or when the dove behind leaves
tells a secret like a singer swinging her body behind a screen.
How I miss the breeze of those dawns where my friends' scent lingers,
wind which sways the myrtle, wafts its fragrance to them far away
lifting & lowering the branches as palm fronds clap along to bird song.

[She, washing dresses]

She, washing dresses in the rain
of my tears, then spreading them in her sunlight

to dry, has no need of springs with my
two eyes, nor sun, given how she shines.

[My heart is in the east]

My heart is in the east, while I'm in the far west
how can I savor the food in my mouth?

How make good my pledges & vows, with Zion
tied down by Edom & I'm in Arab bonds?

As easy to leave all the fineness of Spain
as it would be sweet to see the ruins of the Shrine